Under Horror

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Warhammer 40.000

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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by Depressed_Ferret

Summary

A Halloween Special for our Favorite Duo deep in the labyrinthine bowels of the Underhive!

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Drip... Drip... Drip... the cavern echoed, deep into the labyrinthine expanse of twisting, turning tunnels that stunk of mildew and mold. The stagnant, earthy stench drifted heavily through the expansive tunnel in a smog, so thick it hid the muck and mire of the flooded stonework that swallowed boots.

Adora curled further into herself, pulling tightly on the frayed rags of a poncho in the useless hope of keeping the dripping pipe-rain from soaking any further.

The *plink plink plink* of condensation droplets against her soaked hood proved it was worthless, but Throne-dammit she was *trying.*

"Hah-!" she hissed as a lucky droplet landed in her eye, the cold water stinging as she tried to rub it out, and not for the first time Adora glares up at the glittering ceiling. When they first entered the cave-like tunnel system she had been awestruck at the bright, bioluminescent algae that shone in a gentle blue. *It's beautiful,* Adora thought, *Just like the lumen-trees that lit the Alethros villa*.....

And then the water happened.

At first there was just a slight damp, and she was fine with it- *Hell, it was an improvement to the dry, dark tunnels before* -and then there were small puddles, which Catra warned her to stay away from. Adora ignored her, saying *"it's just a little water, I can handle it!"*

Never in her *life* has Adora ever wanted to strangle herself until then, when she was happily splashing away like it was one of the rain days at the villa.

Because then the puddles got bigger, and *bigger*, and *Bigger* until now: knee deep, ice cold, and with a soft, muddy floor that sucked at her boots. Then it started raining from leaking, semi-frozen pipes, further making this whole journey miserable and

cold. So wet they needed to trade with a small caravan for their ill-fitting hooded ponchos, both of which have long since soaked thru.

In short, Adora hated it here.

And a quick glance showed that her feline companion felt the same, if her soaking mane and deep frown were anything to go by. Honestly, Adora felt terrible for the Abhuman, since with her large ears and poofy mane she was unable to wear a hood; and it must be miserable having to drag her bare feet along the icy, muddy floor...

"How are you holding up?" Adora asked her friend, hoping some conversation might cheer her up.

Catra turned to her, a tired smile plastered on her face, "I'm fine," she said, "The canal isn't dangerous this time of year, so we'll be fine."

Well that's worrying.....

"Is it normally dangerous?" she asked, brows furrowed as Catra's hand moved in a *so-so* gesture. "It depends," she shrugged, "I've nearly drowned when the current starts flowing during the high-tide months, and sometimes there are nasty critters that try to get my toes; but then there are months like this where it's just cold and low." For a moment Adora just stared at her friend, blue eyes wide and mouth agape at the casual mention of *nearly dying,* as if that was *normal!*

.....And then she remembered where they were.

"So you've been here before?" Adora asked, both awestruck and horrified at her admission.

Catra smiles whistfully, black fur poofing slightly as an audible rumbling came from the other girl. "They gave me food!" she says, with enough reverence to make it sound like such a kindness was something to be cherished.

.....And then she remembered where they were.

"So there's a group of people living here?"

Catra nods, "They're a pretty big place connected to a trade route, so that's how we'll get around. We'll have to beg kindness, and that *should* get us a ferry down to *Sectorio Arima,* where we'll hopefully be able to join with a caravan." Adora slowly bobbed her head, seeing the logic in such a plan, except... "Beg kindness?" she asks, brow raised.

Mismatched eyes blink for a moment before turning to her, "Have you never begged kindness before?"

Adora shook her head.

Catra tilted hers, "I thought you were allowed to go to church?"

"I... I *was?* What does that have to do with *'begging kindness'?"*

Now she's staring at Adora as if she's sprouted a third head. "How else are you supposed to ask for help from strangers?" Catra asks, "The Father says we're supposed to help those in need of the *Kindness of Man;* so if you're desperate, you're supposed to *beg kindness."*

Adora blinks, then nods. She's *never* heard of such a thing in all her times going to the chapel and listening to the Holy Sermons. Maybe it's an Underhive thing? "Wait-" she starts, "If you can beg kindness, then why were you starving?" If all Catra had to do was *'beg kindness,'* then why did she have so many horrible stories of going hungry, or passing out from dehydration? *Surely* someone should've helped her!

She shook her head, "Not everywhere is as nice as these folk," she explains, "If I tried to beg kindness before we came to the tunnels, I'd probably be shot or gutted."

.....Adora can't help but hear the unsaid *"or worse,"* and that fills her with an even deeper sense of dread.

What kind of Hell have you lived through....?

She was about to comment when Catra stilled, and Adora followed. The Abhuman's ears swiveled and flicked as she subtly turned her head from side-to-side, listening to some faroff echoes too soft for Adora's hearing to pick up. Mismatched eyes closed as Catra focussed, and Adora held her breath.

One... Two... Three...

She exhaled, and in a soft whisper asked her friend *"What is it?"*

Catra's face scrunched up in thought, "I think we're close."

Adora smiled, "Well let's keep going!"

So deeper and deeper into the freezing waters they trudged, getting closer to their destination with each step.

The first sign of civilization was the low, echoing of noise bouncing along the ancient stonework. There were voices and cheers and even music all smashed together in a cheerful symphony of chaos, one that filled Adora with a vague hope of something *other* than horror and strife. And as the duo trudged further thru the muck and mire, a new sign of civilization was something amazing, something that pushed both Noble and Abhuman to practically *sprint* further and further into the tunnels.....

Food!

Pumping their legs as fast as they could thru the thick, muddy floor the two raced forward, mouths already watering from days and *days* of barely eating. Halfway there Catra growled *"Screw it!"* and *leapt* into the water! Adora watched in amazement as her friend began swimming faster and *faster.....*

"Wait for me!" she cried, diving after her friend.

After nearly an *hour* of swimming thru freezing, chest-high waters Adora could see it, a *town!* Paper lanterns lit the place, over pathways and signs, strung from scrap-metal roofs and the merchant stalls of a beautiful bazaar the likes of which she's never seen! And the *smells!* Spices of all kinds; meats being boiled, fried and roasted; dishes of so many varieties she's never seen!

So distracted by the sights, Adora nearly screamed when she was suddenly hoisted out of the water.

Her muscles tensed as a large, clawed hand tightly gripped her shoulder.

Her hand fell to the hilt of her saber-

"Welcome!" a deep, gravely voice *boomed,* pulling Adora from her panic; and looking up, she nearly screamed at the hulking *thing* before her.

It was twice her height, and nearly as broad as she was tall with thick, scaly hide. Its face was like a man's, but *wrong,* too long and flat, like a reptile *pretending* to be a person. With glowing, yellowy eyes and slitted pupils it stared down at her, its maw curled upward to reveal it's sharp, *hungry teeth-*

"You look pale as a Haunt!" the monster... *gasped?* "Not to worry, Meztli will look after you two!" It said... *reassuringly?*

What???

Suddenly Adora was being ushered into town, Catra beside her. The place was a ramshackle as everywhere else in the Underhive, but it all felt... *better,* somehow. There were no pockmarks from gunfire, no burns from explosions; instead there were children- *around her and Catra's age* -excitedly walking from stall-to-stall and grabbing small trinkets or snacks, and.....

They weren't violent.

Steely-blue eyes widened to saucers as she spied a large monster nearly twice the height of their- ~~*captor? butcher?*~~ -escort, its green scales covered in crisscrossing scars of all kinds, with what looked like a *dozen* tiny children clinging to its long, wide tail. They were laughing as it dragged them along, the ones who lost their grip running to catch up and grab back on. Like a game.

A *game.*

Looking more closely Adora took notice of the people all around: there were reptilian giants, furred folk like Catra or that Oxen fellow, some with gills or webbed digits, even normal Humans of hues both normal and strange.....

"Here you are!" she's snapped from her overload of information by the giant. ~~It~~ *They* have brought the duo to a rather large building, a sign in some script she can't read, and the distinct stench of smoke wafting from inside. "Mez' will get you two warmed up, and give you a nice, dry change of clothes!" the giant smiles, gently patting them on the back before walking off.

Shame and guilt well up in her gut, and she wants to apologize to the kind person- *she can't tell what they are* -but Catra's already pulling her along.

As they step through the doors, Adora shivers at the sudden wave of heat that wraps around her freezing form, the source of which is a *large* fireplace at the far end of the room. Mismatched tables of all shapes and heights fill the room with chairs of equally random heights and builds, making Adora come to think this is some sort of tavern or inn.

Catra said those were common in the large Underhive settlements, so this was *probably* one of those?

"Welcome!" greeted a kind voice, drawing Adora's gaze from the fire to the speaker. She was tall and willowy, and looked remarkably Human except for the reddish scales going from across the bridge of her nose, the curve of her cheek bones, down

her neck and along the backs of her arms; the rest covered by her clothes. Slitted green eyes regarded the pair before widening, "You're soaked to the bone!" she cried, rushing to a nearby cabinet.

Adora watched her move, so *Human* despite the long, reptilian tail that swished beneath her skirt, and black-clawed feet. She wasn't awkward, or fumbling, she was almost like Catra in a way. The mutations clearly didn't hinder her in any way she could see.

"Here we are!" the woman smiled, showing her sharp teeth as she came bearing thick, warm blankets, "Now let's get you two settled so you can bathe and get dressed, how's that sound?"

It... It honestly sounded *wonderful* to Adora.

Glancing beside her, it was clear Catra thought the same.

"Are you sure?" the feline asked, her black fur bristling despite being soaked, "We don't have much to trade-"

The lizard-woman waved her off, "I'll not take coin nor trade," she says, "The Festival is upon us, and I won't dishonor our Holy Father by taking advantage of you children."

For a moment, they both just stood there, staring at perhaps the kindest woman they've met on their journey.

"O Holy Emperor on Thine Golden Throne, I shall never again take for granted the sweetest bliss of warm water; and I thank You for this most Holy Blessing, Amen." Adora gave a quick prayer to the Emperor as she flopped onto the bed with a satisfied smile, wrapped in the warm clothes that Abhuman woman left for her. It was lumpy, and the sheets were a bit scratchy from patch-jobs, but it was *Heavenly!* After weeks of laying on hard floors, it was like a gift from Holy Terra!

It was so comfy Adora nearly fell asleep then-and-there until-

BANG!

"AH!" she shrieked as a sudden weight tackled her to the bed!

"Adora!" the familiar voice of Catra cried, "Feel how soft my fur is!"

Pulling back from her friend, Adora looked at-

At.....

"Catra....?" she gasped.

The face in front of her was a chocolatey brown, with splotches of black and darker browns speckled like aggressive freckles. What was once a matted, mottled hair was now a floofy mane of browns and blacks. This wasn't the face she's known for the past few weeks. This wasn't the black-furred cat that helped Adora navigate the horrid morass that was the Underhive.

But those mismatched eyes were unmistakable, blue and gold like jewels.

"They had soap!" Catra preens, showing off her cleaned fur along her face, arms and legs.

"You- *You look so different!"* she gasps, amazed at her friend's transformation, "You were black!"

Catra nods, looking a little sheepish, "I'll probably be black for a while," she says, "Where I lived was near a lot of really bad chemicals..."

"Well you look great!" she smiles, scritching behind her friend's ear. A deep, rumbling purr is her reward.

No Sad Cat!

Not on MY watch.....

"So are they usually this nice?" Adora asks, still stritching her friend's ear. Catra purrs before pulling away and shaking her head, "They were really nice, but not..." she gestures around them, and Adora nods, "Yeah." Which makes Adora even *more* curious. "Do you know what festival that woman was talking about?" Again Catra shakes her head, "There's a *LOT* of small differences in worship across the Underhive. One area might celebrate something nobody else has heard about."

Well damn.

The smell of cooked meat pulls them both from their thoughts as they turn towards the door, Catra's tail sticking straight up and ears perked. "Hello, dears!" the woman- *Meztli?* -chimes, carrying two plates of steaming-

"What is that?"

On the plate are a bunch of folded, toasted breads drizzled with some sort of chunky, dark sauce; and on the side is some sort of fried tube-things. Even from here she could smell the spices, something that burned the nose, mixed with something sweet and giving off a wonderfully savory scent. It was wonderful and like nothing Adora had ever seen or smelled before.

Meztli smiles as she hands them the plates, "Just some local foods," she explains, "We don't normally have bread, so I'm sorry if it's a bit burnt."

"Thank you." Adora bows her head as the woman leaves, before turning to Catra. Before she could ask her friend if it was safe to eat, the catgirl's already started tearing into the fried tubes with a satisfying *crunch,* and Adora can see the moment her mismatched eyes begin to sparkle.

"It's meat!" she says, digging in, occasionally stopping to suck in air. At her expression, Catra explains "It's spicy."

'.....I've never had spicy food before,' Adora thought, hesitantly grabbing one of the folded flatbreads. Up close she could see

some sort of melted cheese holding it together on the inside with the chunky sauce looking like something chopped or diced.

She took a bite.

Her eyes widened in surprise at the exotic flavors-

The sharp tang of the melted cheese mixed with the hot, tender flavors of the shredded meat in a fiery blend, tempered by a slightly sour sweetness of some sort of fruit. It burned her mouth and opened her nostrils, and Adora could feel her face start to heat up.

It's amazing!

Taking another bite she got some of the chunky sauce, with her tongue doused in a sweet, watery flavor that eased the flame without snuffing the taste!

"Veez r sho hood!" Adora mumbled her words as she ate, Catra nodding along with her tail swish-swishing behind her.

In only a matter of minutes they've both practically destroyed the food, Adora even made a game of tossing scraps at Catra to see if she could catch them.

She never missed!

"Hey," Adora began, sitting up on her bed, "Do you want to walk around a bit? See the *'Festival'* they're talking about?"

Catra's tail slowly swished back and forth as she hummed in thought, before nodding.

And that's how they ended up walking around the busy streets, taking in the various sights and sounds around them. Performers played songs on drums and bow-string instruments, some blowing on bags that made strange wails and others shook club-like things that rattled. Dancers spun, tapped, or stomped to certain tunes; some jeering and challenging others, some inviting anyone to

come by and join in. Vendors gave away trickets and gifts of all kinds, wares both practical and material and all of them unique. Great rows of stands handed out snacks, meals and foods so exotic and queer Adora didn't know how to eat most of them-

But she really liked this one stall that had spit-roasted meat stuffed in bread, covered in sweet sauce and filled with a sharp-tasting root vegetable!

It was called a *'doner,'* or something like that!

Children of all shapes and sizes ran around, cloaked in costumes of all kinds. Adora herself saw several Guardsmen, a few Hussars and those of the Tech-Cult. Catra growled whenever she saw the red robes, though.

When she asked a vendor selling masks what this was all for, she was greeted with a smile. "It's to honor those long past," the woman said, gesturing to the various alters of skulls and such venerated with candles, "To give thanks to those who died to protect us," several weapons were seen wrapped in scrolls of prayers, "And to frighten any foul spirits or beasts who would prey on those we love."

To prove her point, Catra then leapt at a large rat-creature, her fangs ripping into its spine even as the little terror squeaked and shrieked.

Both Adora and the woman smiled.

"So what is this celebration called?" Adora asked.

Again the old woman smiled.

"The Feast of Remembrance."

End Notes

Happy Halloween!!! I hope you all have a fun, safe holiday full of scares and delicious candy! And to those who don't celebrate, have a great October 31st!

I also tried putting in a lot of different traditions, and I hope you all enjoyed it!

I'll try to write more!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!